
POLISH EARLY MUSIC

Editorial principles

The rules of the series



Sources · Pitch and notation · Editorial signs · Underlay · Text · Chant · Paratext

GUIDE

by Mikołaj Derduń

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POLISH EARLY MUSIC. *Editorial principles*. First edition, 2026. By Mikołaj Derduń.

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/principles>.

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HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

EVERY EDITION in the series follows these rules. The editions do not repeat them: an edition's method section gives only what is particular to its piece, and cites a rule by number where it matters ('principles 10.1' is rule 1 of section 10). Where an edition departs from a rule, its method or critical notes say so and give the reason.

The guide is generated from the series repository, where the rules are kept and revised. A rule changes here first, and every edition follows.

1. STANCE

1. *Go to the first-degree source.* Edit from the manuscript, print or facsimile, never from a modern edition when the source can be seen.
2. *Distrust critical editions, this one included.* A modern edition is a witness to its editor's choices, not to the composer's.
3. *A modern edition is not evidence of a composer's habits* below the level of structure. Spijker's editions of Wacław were reliable for repeat marks and melisma placement at cadences, and unreliable for syllable-by-syllable placement. Underlay statistics must come from period prints or manuscripts.
4. *The music decides when the evidence runs out.* Underlay in particular must be 'above all musical and meaningful'; if that means departing from the source, depart and say so.
5. *Say what is editorial.* Every category of editorial intervention is stated in the method section and signalled in the score (section 8).

2. TWO EDITIONS, ONE SCORE

Every piece is published as a critical edition and a performance edition.

1. *The score is the same in both.* Note values, barring, voice names and editorial signs do not change. The performance edition simplifies the paratext. No reduced values, no modern barring, no piano reduction, no stripping of editorial signs.
2. *Pitch is the one exception.* The critical edition stays at written pitch. The performance edition may be transposed when the written pitch does not suit a modern SATB choir, and its clefs follow the new ranges (an Altus in the octave treble clef becomes a treble clef). The masthead says so in one line, and a transposed edition drops the incipits, which would show the source's pitch.
 - *High clefs (chiavette):* transpose by the period's own interval, argued from period theory in the critical edition. *Vox in Rama* goes a fifth down.
 - *Low clefs (chiavi naturali):* no period rule asks for upward transposition; written pitch fixed only the relation between the voices, and the pitch was set by the director or the organ. Choose the interval from the voice ranges, by the time each voice spends in its comfortable range, not by its extremes alone. *Już się zmierzka* goes a minor third up.
3. *Editorial suggestions* that go beyond the source (an octave drop at a final, say) appear only in the performance edition, as small notes in round brackets, explained in one sentence.
4. *Final editions contain no working material.* No scripts, statistics, 'consulted' remarks, notes to self or status flags. The research record lives in this repository (issues and notes/).

5. *Gaps*. Name only gaps in the primary sources (a lost print, an unseen facsimile, an uncollated witness), in one sentence in the Sources section. Unseen secondary literature is not listed; it goes to the issue tracker.

3. SOURCES AND SIGLA

1. *Sigla* of sources and editions are set in a thin ring (one letter) or rounded frame (several), so that a source A is never read as the word 'a' and never confused with the voice A. Voice abbreviations are plain small capitals.
2. *Base text* is the earliest complete witness that can be read. Where that is a facsimile of a lost source, the facsimile is the base and the lost source keeps its own siglum.
3. *Choosing sigla*. Short capitals. Use a letter for the source's own name or shelfmark (T = Tenor primi chori; K = Kraków BJ 1619). Where older literature numbers sources differently, follow the shelfmark and say why in one sentence.
4. *Collated editions* get sigla too (PWM, K, M, R, N), listed separately under 'Editions collated'.
5. *Derivative editions*. Where two modern editions agree in every note, including accidentals the source lacks, they share a parent and count as one witness. Say so.
6. *Recordings* may be collated for accidentals and underlay 'as heard', with a siglum (P = Schola Gregoriana Pragensis, *Plaude*). The edition's reading still rests on the source and the counterpoint, not on the recording.
7. *Lost voices*. Where only some voices survive in the source, the title page and method state which voices come from the source and which from modern editions.
8. *Earlier readings*. When an editor's change (Perz, say) is weighed against the source, each critical note ends with a verdict in small capitals: SOURCE RESTORED or [EDITOR] ACCEPTED.

4. PITCH

1. *Print at written pitch*. The critical score keeps the source's final, signature and clef relations.
2. *Pitch must be semi-reasonable for singers*. 'All for historical pitch, but the pitch has to be semi-reasonable for singers to begin with.' The performance notes give the written ranges and the transposition a modern choir will usually take; the notation does not change.
3. *Unclefed sources*. Choose the pitch level by testing the counterpoint: the right level gives consonance on the strong beats; moving any one voice by a step gives dissonance throughout. State that pitch and signature are editorial.
4. *Chiavette*: see 2.2.. Evidence for the interval (fourth or fifth) comes from period theory (Banchieri, Picerli, Doni, Praetorius), the bass range test and the notation the transposition produces.
5. *Octave of a voice*. Test with voice-crossing counts against neighbouring voices before accepting or emending an octave.

5. NOTE VALUES, BARRING, SIGNS

1. *Unreduced values*. Note values are those of the source. Where the source is an organ tablature that halves its vocal model, double them.
2. *Bar = breve* under cut-C. Bar numbers count breves, including both endings of a repeat.
3. *Mensurstriche*. Bar lines run between the staves only, dashed, so that the score reads as parts first and as a timed score second. A note that crosses a bar line keeps its single value; the edition adds no ties. Section, repeat and final bar lines are solid.

4. *Mensuration sign* as printed in the source. Where the source has none (a tablature, an unclefed manuscript), the edition may supply one and says in the method that it is editorial. The score must read without it: the light bar lines carry the time for those who want it.
5. *Incipits* before each staff give the source's clef, sign and first note wherever a mensural source gives them. None where the source is a tablature, unclefed or lost.
6. *Ambitus* of each voice after the clef.
7. *Longs*. A long at a final is the period's way of saying what a modern editor says with a fermata: hold until all voices have finished. So:
 - Print the source's long at every final: the end of the piece, and the end of a section, a *pars* or a repeated half where the source marks the break.
 - Add no fermata over a long. Print a fermata (corona) only where the source has one.
 - A long inside a phrase is a measured value, not a hold. Print it as such.
 - A long that must end with the other voices but enters late is scaled to its real length. A maxima in one voice only may be given as a long, with a note.
8. *Rests*. In the performance edition every rest is cut at the bar lines and grouped by the bar, so that entries can be counted; notes are never cut (5.3), because a cut note implies a tie, while a cut rest changes nothing that sounds. The critical edition keeps the rests of a primary source as written, with their groupings; voices taken from a modern edition are regularised as in the performance edition.

6. CLEFS AND VOICE NAMES

1. *Voice names* are the source's (Cantus, Altus, Tenor, Bassus; Discantus, Medius, Tenor), in Latin, in small capitals, abbreviated after the first system.
2. *Modern clefs* are treble, octave treble and bass. The original clefs appear in the incipit and the Sources entry.
3. 'Tenor' names a function, not a range.

7. ACCIDENTALS

1. *Source accidentals* stand before the note.
2. *Editorial accidentals* stand above the note, small, without brackets, and apply to that note only.
 - *Optional accidentals* are bracketed above the note: the note as printed is the edition's reading, the bracketed sign an alteration singers may make. Use them where the period rules leave a real choice; give the reason in the critical notes. Paired alterations (a double leading-tone cadence) are marked in both voices and the notes say 'both or neither'. (Berger 1987)
3. *Accidental style 'forget'*: a sign governs only its own note; no cautionaries.
4. *Grounds*. Editorial accidentals rest on period rules: no *mi contra fa* between voices; a sixth opening to an octave at a cadence is major; *una nota super la*. Where the rules conflict, the critical note explains the choice. Parallel fifths count as grounds for a natural.
5. *Consistency*. At a double leading-tone cadence, sharpen both voices or neither, never one.
6. *Every editorial accidental must be justified*. If an accidental appears in a modern edition and not in the source, it is editorial and must be weighed, not inherited.
7. When modern-edition accidentals must stand for a lost voice, the method says so.

long notes, where the choice is textural rather than declamatory, they may stand on the beat. The voices need not change syllable together. These are tendencies to weigh by ear, not rules to count: sing every line before settling it. This matters most where an edition underlays from scratch.

7. *Wacław's own practice* (Kraków *Lamentationes*, 1553): mostly syllabic, repeated notes take new syllables; one melisma before each cadence, on the stressed syllable of the last word; the final syllable on the cadence note; short repeats *ij*, longer ones written out.
8. *Accent* follows the penultimate rule as taught in Kraków (Sebastian z Felsztyna, 1518).
9. *Repeated notes* take a new syllable unless semiminims (Stoquerus). Long free melismas may be replaced by repeating the clause.
10. *Imitation*. A point of imitation carries the words of its head motif wherever it recurs.
11. *Source guides*. Where the source prints text in blocks, use its spacing (gaps mark melismas) and the voice whose text fits note for note.
12. *Departures* from the theorists that the source itself shows are kept and noted.
13. *Lower voices* that are editorially texted may skip words to keep long notes, as long as their text makes sense alone. Divide notes only where text requires it, mark the division with a dashed tie, and avoid movement before the penultimate bar at a final cadence.
14. *Strophic songs*. Underlay as many stanzas as the music needs. Where the underlay is the same in every stanza, stanza 1 goes under the notes and the rest follow the score. Where a later stanza needs different underlay (a different stress pattern, an extra syllable, a melisma that would fall on a weak syllable), that stanza goes under the notes too. Weigh how the piece is usually performed: if most performances sing one or two stanzas, those two matter most.
15. Theorists are cited by paraphrase; direct quotation is not needed.

11. TEXT

1. *Latin*: classical spelling (*expectatione*, *Iudaeorum*), *et* for &, *u/v* distinguished. Punctuation from the relevant liturgical book (Missal 1570 for *Vox*).
2. *Old Polish*: modern spelling and punctuation, old sounds and forms kept (*zmierzka*, *naszem*, *wszytki*, *swoję*, *jenż*). Do not modernise to *zmierzcha*, *naszym*, *On*.
3. *Diplomatic text* in the critical edition keeps the source's spelling and line division (f kept, abbreviations unexpanded).
4. *Translation* is literal, line by line. Archaic English only where the source language is liturgical verse.
5. *Pronunciation* lives in one series guide (guides/pronunciation), not in each edition. An edition notes only what is peculiar to its text (a word that needs a gloss, an option the text invites) and points to the guide. Defaults: Polish Latin for Latin texts; modern pronunciation of the old forms for Polish. Tables, never paragraphs.
6. *Spellings of the source* are kept in lemmata and in the edited text where they are not errors (*confidencium*, *misericordie*).
7. *Translations of quotations*. Every quotation in a language other than English, in either edition, carries an English translation inline: after the original, in parentheses and quotation marks, '...' ('...'). A block quotation is followed by its translation inside the same block. Titles of works are translated at their first mention in the prose where the meaning matters to the argument; not in source lists or the literature.

12. CHANT

1. Base text and melody from the oldest notated witness; neume grouping follows it.
2. Square notation, unmeasured. Mensural or modern rhythmic readings are reported, not adopted.
3. Bar lines are editorial and mark verse structure. *Mora vocis* only at stanza ends.
4. No B-flat unless the base witness has it.
5. Faint or invisible notes: say so in a note; supply from parallels and earlier transcriptions.
6. Later hands are described, not normalised away.

13. PARATEXT

Critical edition: Title page, colophon and contents, Introduction (the piece, composer, poet, context), Sources, Editorial method, Text and translation, [Facsimile], Score, Critical notes, Literature.

Performance edition: Masthead (with a pitch line if transposed), Score, stanzas after the score, then Text and translation and For rehearsal (the song, the words, stanzas, pitch and voices, tempo, the score's signs), colophon line. No context before the music: setting the scene is the director's job, and the rehearsal notes give them what they need for it.

1. Context is welcome in both: 'enough paratext for both performers and critical readers'. In the performance edition it is limited to what changes how one sings.
2. Distinguish verified citations from the editor's own readings. Write 'my own reading' where no published study makes the link.
3. Verify every claim before printing it; cut what cannot be verified.
4. *Do not restate the series rules in an edition.* The rules live in one place, the series guide *Editorial principles* (this document, also kept in the repository as docs/editorial-principles.md). An edition's method section says only what is particular to the piece: its sources, the choices the rules leave open, and every departure from a rule, with the reason. Where a rule is meant, name it and cite it by number ('principles 10.1'). Restating rules makes the editions repetitive and lets them drift out of step with each other and with this file.
5. *The performance edition argues from the music, not from names.* It gives the reason for a choice in general terms ('as an organ would have done'), never by pointing to what a particular ensemble, recording or modern edition does. Specific citations, if they matter, belong in the critical edition.

14. NAMES, ATTRIBUTION, RIGHTS

1. *Composers by their vernacular names only* (Piotr z Grudziądza, Wacław z Szamotuł, Mikołaj Zielenieński). Latin forms appear only where the prose discusses them, such as a signature in a source. An anonymous work is credited to *Anonymous*, with its date in the composer's dates slot.
2. *Title and subtitle.*
 - *Title:* the work's title in its main source (a heading, a rubric, a table of contents), in the source's language. If the source gives none, the incipit.
 - *Subtitle:* if the title is not the incipit, the incipit (*Modlitwa gdy dziatki spać idą / Już się zmierzka*). If the title is the incipit, the work's liturgical or functional designation in the source's language (*Vox in Rama / Communio in festo SS. Innocentium*). If neither applies, no subtitle.
 - Alternative titles go in the introduction. The collection or print a piece belongs to goes in the source line. Scoring goes in the forces line ('for four voices'), never in the subtitle.

3. *Editor*: Mikołaj Derduń, withń.
4. *Series*: Polish Early Music, numbered in order of first edition.
5. *Licence*: editorial text, scores and sources under CC BY 4.0; build code under MIT. The music is public domain. Facsimile images only where their holder's terms allow (Leipzig and Polona images are public domain).
6. *Edition numbering*: 'First edition, 2026'. Corrections that change readings make a new edition; typographic fixes do not.